Newbie Blues

The struggling years common to every fresh face are unusually tough for the tall, lanky baritone with a passion for acting. Finally, it's his talent that speaks

1950s-60s
After studying at St Mary's and Boys' High School in Allahabad, at his boarding school in Nainital, Sherwood College, his thespian skills are honed as he plays the Mayor in Gogol's play *The Government Inspector*, winning the Kendall Cup for best actor in 1957, at age 15. Alongside his BSc from Kirori Mal College in New Delhi, the acting bug stays constant. Joins its theatre society, The Players.

1968-69
After six dull years with a couple of desk jobs in Calcutta, begins his attempt to find his metier in cinema. Brother Ajitabh responds to an ad seeking new talent by taking a box camera picture of his brother outside Victoria Memorial and sends it to the Filmfare Madhuri Talent Contest. Amitabh doesn't get the call.

Ajitabh's friend tells them director K.A. Abbas was looking for a new face. Bachchan, then 27, makes his debut in Abbas's ***Saat Hindustani***, playing a Muslim poet who joins the nationalists to liberate Goa from Portuguese rule. It wins him his first National Award, as best newcomer.

1971-72
In ***Anand***, Amitabh makes his presence felt as a brooding doctor-friend despite all the focus being on the biggest superstar of the day, Rajesh Khanna. Director Hrishikesh Mukherjee, by now aware of Amitabh's talent, reputedly trims his role in ***Guddi*** because he doesn't want to waste

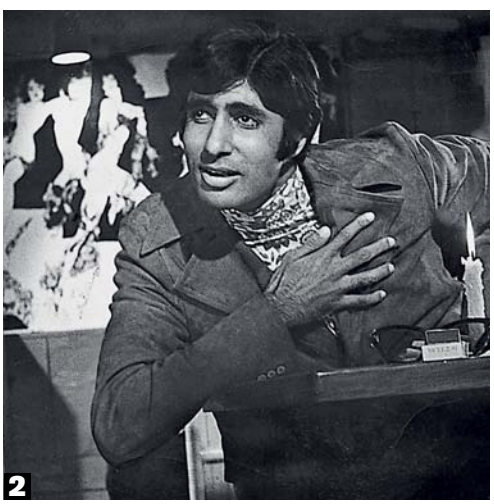


INDIA PICTURE COLLECTION 1

1 BIG BREAK
Amitabh in his first Hindi movie *Saat Hindustani* (1969)

2 A JOURNEY BEGINS
A still from *Bombay to Goa* (1972)

3 FULL OF LIFE
Rajesh Khanna and Amitabh Bachchan in *Anand* (1971)



INDIA PICTURE COLLECTION 2



3

him in a minor role. Film lore also often dwelt on another 1971 film—Sunil Dutt's ***Reshma Aur Shera*** where Amitabh, notably, plays... a mute man. In 1972, bags his first noteworthy lead role in ***Bombay to Goa*** (1972). Later that year, appears with Jaya Bhaduri in their first feature, ***Ek Nazar***. Love blossoms. And a rich cinema partnership begins.

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